

Reading Response Paper 2

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The key differences between sciences of nature and sciences of culture are what they aim to study. Specifically, sciences of nature seeks to explain the occurrences of the world while the sciences of culture focus on understanding these occurrences. The differences between sciences of nature and sciences of culture were very nicely laid out in the Geisteswissenschaften reading. For starters, my interpretation between “understanding” and “explaining” is noting the differences between “why” and “how”. The natural sciences seek to explain the working mechanics of how the world works and what laws govern it, while cultural sciences focus on understanding why the world came to be what it is now through the perspectives of its actors.

Specifically in the Geisteswissenschaften reading, it analyzes the methods, goals, approaches and object of study between geisteswissenschaften and naturwissenschaften. Mainly, geisteswissenschaften focuses on the humans and the actors of the world whilst naturwissenschaften focuses more on the functionality of the world itself. In the reading, Dilthey describes natural sciences as a monoethic science which aim to create a system of laws and concepts to somehow generalize the diverse phenomena that is the world we live in. On the other hand, the cultural sciences focus on events in their singularity and seek to understand the event and its becoming.

However, in Peel’s “Epistemic Values in the Humanities and the Sciences”, he argues that Dilthey’s notion of explaining and understanding is actually misguided. Peel argues that the humanities (cultural sciences) also seek to explain, although explaining holds a more important role in the natural sciences. Peel argued that historians often find themselves explaining why historical events occurred from both a causal explanations and intentional explanations. Causal explanations referring to events occurring because of a previous event(s) and intentional explanations referring to actions taken due to beliefs and values of the actor. Peel additionally argues that the humanities have epistemic values as an object of study while the sciences largely do not. As such, Peel argues while the humanities and sciences have similar epistemic values, their methods and objects of study vary, which is what separate them apart as different fields of study.

Thus although Peel seems to disagree with some of the statements made by Dilthey about the humanities and the natural sciences, they do agree that the key distinctions between these fields lie in the differences in their objects of study and their methods.